

DRYWALL PRO

THE COMPLETE DRYWALL MASTERY GUIDE

Master framing, hanging, taping, and finishing. From absolute beginner
to professional installer — at your own pace.



TABLE OF CONTENTS

01	Introduction to Drywall
02	Essential Tools & Equipment
03	Understanding Framing
04	Planning Your Project
05	Cutting Drywall
06	Hanging Drywall on Walls
07	Hanging Drywall on Ceilings
08	Corners and Angles
09	Joint Taping Basics
10	Applying Joint Compound
11	Second & Third Coats
12	Finishing Levels Explained
13	Sanding Techniques
14	Priming & Painting Prep
15	Drywall Textures
16	Drywall Repairs
17	Moisture & Mold Prevention
18	Sound & Fire Rating
19	Insulation Integration

20 Working Efficiently

21 Quality Checklist

01

INTRODUCTION TO DRYWALL

Drywall (also called sheetrock, plasterboard, or wallboard) is the most widely used interior wall and ceiling finish in modern construction. It replaced traditional lath-and-plaster methods because it's faster to install, more affordable, and delivers consistent results.

What Is Drywall?

Drywall is a panel made of gypsum plaster pressed between two thick sheets of paper. The gypsum core provides fire resistance, while the paper facing gives it structural integrity and a smooth finish surface.

Types of Drywall Boards

Type	Thickness	Use	Identifier
Regular (white)	1/2"	Standard walls and ceilings	White face paper
Lightweight	1/2"	Same as regular, 25% lighter	"UltraLight" branding
Fire-Rated (Type X)	5/8"	Garages, furnace rooms, party walls	Red text/markings
Moisture-Resistant	1/2" or 5/8"	Bathrooms, kitchens (not showers)	Green face paper
Mold-Resistant	1/2" or 5/8"	High-humidity areas	Purple or yellow face
Cement Board	1/4" or 1/2"	Tile backing in wet areas	Grey, rigid, heavy
Soundproof	5/8"	Home theaters, bedrooms	"QuietRock" or similar

Standard Sheet Sizes

The most common size is **4' x 8'** (48" x 96"). Sheets also come in 4' x 10', 4' x 12', and 54" wide panels for 9-foot ceilings. Thickness ranges from 1/4" (curved walls) to 5/8" (fire-rated).

PRO TIP

Longer sheets mean fewer joints. If your ceiling height allows, use 10' or 12' sheets to reduce taping work by 20-30%.

02

ESSENTIAL TOOLS & EQUIPMENT

Having the right tools makes the difference between a frustrating day and a professional result. Here's everything you need, organized by task.

Measuring & Layout

- **T-square (48")** — Essential for marking straight cuts across full sheets
- **Tape measure (25')** — For measuring walls, ceilings, and openings
- **Chalk line** — Snapping reference lines for stud locations on floors/ceilings
- **Pencil** — Carpenter's pencil or standard #2 for marking
- **Level (4')** — Checking plumb on studs and corners

Cutting Tools

- **Utility knife** — Sharp blade for scoring. Replace blades often (every 2-3 sheets)
- **Jab saw (keyhole saw)** — Cutting outlets, boxes, and irregular shapes
- **Drywall router/rotary tool** — Fast outlet cutouts; Rotozip is the industry standard
- **Rasp/surform** — Smoothing rough edges after cutting
- **Circle cutter** — Perfect circles for recessed lights

Hanging Tools

- **Screw gun** — Dedicated drywall screw gun with adjustable depth clutch; or a drill with dimpler bit
- **Drywall screws** — 1-1/4" coarse thread for wood studs, 1" fine thread for steel
- **Drywall lift** — Mechanical lift for ceiling panels (rent one for ~\$40/day)
- **Panel carrier** — Two-person or one-person grip handle for moving sheets

Taping & Finishing Tools

- **Taping knives** — 6", 10", and 12" stainless steel for applying compound in progressively wider coats
- **Mud pan (12")** — Holds compound while you work
- **Inside corner tool** — Creates crisp 90° inside corners in one pass
- **Outside corner tool** — Smooths compound over corner bead
- **Mixing paddle + drill** — For mixing compound to proper consistency
- **Banjo (tape dispenser)** — Applies tape and compound simultaneously (optional but fast)

Sanding & Finishing

- **Pole sander** — Sand walls and ceilings without a ladder
- **Sanding sponge** — Wet sanding for dust-free finishing
- **Sandpaper** — 120-grit (rough), 150-grit (medium), 220-grit (fine)
- **Work light (LED)** — Raking light to reveal imperfections before painting

Safety Gear

- **N95 respirator** — Mandatory for sanding (silica dust is hazardous)
- **Safety glasses** — Protect eyes from dust and debris
- **Work gloves** — Paper edges can cut; compound dries out skin
- **Knee pads** — Essential for floor-level work

PRO TIP

Start with the essentials: utility knife, T-square, screw gun, 6" and 10" tapping knives, mud pan, sanding sponge, and safety gear. Total: under \$200. Add specialty tools as you grow.

03

UNDERSTANDING FRAMING

Before hanging a single sheet, you need to understand the framing behind it. The frame is the skeleton that holds your drywall, and mistakes here show up as cracks, pops, and uneven walls later.

Stud Spacing

Spacing	Common Use	Drywall Thickness
16" on center (OC)	Load-bearing walls, most residential	1/2" minimum
24" on center (OC)	Non-load-bearing, some ceilings	5/8" recommended

Wood vs Steel Studs

Wood studs are standard in residential construction. They're easy to work with, accept screws well, and don't require special tools. Use coarse-thread drywall screws (1-1/4").

Steel studs are common in commercial work and basements. They're lighter, straighter, and won't rot or warp. Use fine-thread screws (1") and a screw gun with a steel-stud clutch.

Checking Your Frame

- Plumb** — Hold a 4' level against each stud. Bowed studs cause bumps. Shim or plane them flat.
- Flat** — String a line across studs at mid-height. Every stud face should touch the string. A protruding stud gets planed; a recessed one gets shimmed.
- Blocking** — Add horizontal blocking where you'll mount heavy items (TV brackets, cabinets, grab bars). Mark blocking locations before covering with drywall.
- Nail plates** — Protect wires/pipes that run through studs within 1-1/4" of the face. Required by code.

WARNING

Never hang drywall over a bowed or twisted stud. The drywall will crack along that stud within months. Fix the frame first — it takes 5 minutes now vs. 5 hours of repair later.

04

PLANNING YOUR PROJECT

Proper planning prevents waste, multiple store trips, and budget overruns. Here's how to calculate everything you need.

Measuring the Space

- 1. Measure each wall: width × height
- 2. Measure ceilings: length × width
- 3. Subtract openings (doors = ~21 sq ft, windows = ~15 sq ft each)
- 4. Calculate total square footage

Material Calculator

Material	Formula	Example (12×14 room, 8' ceiling)
Drywall sheets (4×8)	Total sq ft ÷ 32 × 1.10 waste factor	544 ÷ 32 × 1.10 = 19 sheets
Joint compound	1 gallon per 100 sq ft	544 ÷ 100 = 6 gallons
Paper tape	1 roll per 370 linear ft of joints	~2 rolls
Screws	~32 screws per sheet (1 lb per 5 sheets)	~4 lbs
Corner bead	Measure each outside corner	Per measured length

PRO TIP

Always add 10-15% waste factor. Cuts, mistakes, and damaged sheets happen. Buying extra upfront is cheaper than a second delivery.

Order of Work

- 1. Inspect and prep framing
- 2. Install insulation (if applicable)
- 3. Hang ceilings first, then walls
- 4. Cut and fit around outlets, windows, doors
- 5. Apply first coat of tape and compound
- 6. Second coat (wider knife)
- 7. Third coat (widest knife, feather edges)

8. Sand

9. Prime

.0. Final inspection with raking light

05

CUTTING DRYWALL

Clean cuts are the foundation of a professional install. Drywall is forgiving — if you can use a ruler and a knife, you can cut it.

Score-and-Snap (Straight Cuts)

1. Measure and mark on the face side
2. Position T-square at your mark
3. Score through the face paper with a utility knife in one firm pass
4. Snap the sheet away from the cut (bend it back)
5. Cut the back paper with your knife
6. Smooth the edge with a rasp

Cutting Around Outlets & Boxes

1. Measure from the nearest edge and from the floor/ceiling to each side of the box
2. Transfer measurements to the sheet
3. Cut with a jab saw or drywall router
4. For a router: hang the sheet first, then plunge-cut around the box from behind

Cutting Circles (Recessed Lights)

Use a circle cutter adjusted to the correct diameter, or trace the fixture housing and cut with a jab saw. Drill a pilot hole inside the circle first for easy saw entry.

L-Cuts and Notches

Score one leg with a knife, cut the other leg with a jab saw, then snap along the scored line. Always cut the short leg with the saw.

SAFETY

Change utility knife blades every 2-3 sheets. A dull blade requires more pressure, leading to slips and injuries. Fresh blades cut cleaner with less force.

06

HANGING DRYWALL ON WALLS

This is where your project starts to look like something. Proper hanging technique saves hours of taping and finishing later.

Horizontal vs Vertical

Horizontal (landscape) is preferred for walls 8-9 feet tall. Benefits:

- Fewer vertical joints (which are harder to finish)
- Horizontal joints fall at 48" — comfortable working height
- Stronger wall when sheets span more studs

Vertical is used for walls over 9 feet or when sheet length matches wall height.

Step-by-Step Hanging

1. **Start at the top.** Push the top sheet tight against the ceiling. Use a drywall lift or a helper.
2. **Stagger joints.** Never align vertical joints on adjacent rows. Offset by at least one stud bay (16-24").
3. **Screw pattern:** Every 12" along edges, every 16" in the field (center of sheet). Screws should dimple the paper slightly without breaking it.
4. **Leave a 1/4" gap at the floor.** Drywall should never touch the floor — moisture wicks up.
5. **Tight butt joints:** Where two non-tapered ends meet, leave no gap but don't force them together.

Screw Depth

The screw head should sit just below the paper surface, creating a small dimple. Too deep = paper tears, screw loses holding power. Too shallow = bump under compound. Use a screw gun with depth-stop clutch.

PRO TIP

Mark stud locations on the floor and ceiling with a pencil before hanging. Once the drywall is up, snap chalk lines between marks to find studs for screwing the field.

07

HANGING DRYWALL ON CEILINGS

Ceilings are the hardest part of drywall installation — gravity works against you. But with the right technique and tools, even one person can do it.

Key Principles

- Always do ceilings BEFORE walls. Wall sheets support ceiling edges.
- Run sheets perpendicular to joists for maximum strength.
- Use 5/8" drywall for 24" OC joists to prevent sagging.
- Apply construction adhesive (PL Premium) to joists for extra hold.

Using a Drywall Lift

A mechanical lift costs ~\$40/day to rent and turns a two-person job into a one-person job. Position the sheet on the lift, crank it up, fine-adjust, and screw.

Without a Lift

With a helper: one person holds with a T-brace (a 2×4 cut to ceiling height minus 1/4") while the other screws. Start at one end and work across, securing every 12" along joists.

Screw Pattern for Ceilings

Location	Spacing
Edges (within 3/8" of edge)	Every 8"
Field (center studs)	Every 12"

WARNING

Ceiling drywall is heavy. A 4×12 sheet of 5/8" Type X weighs ~100 lbs. Never try to lift it alone without a mechanical lift. Injury risk is real.

08

CORNERS AND ANGLES

Corners are where amateur work shows most. Master these techniques and your installations will look professional.

Inside Corners

1. Fold paper tape along its center crease
2. Apply a bed coat of compound to both sides of the corner
3. Press the folded tape into the corner with a 6" knife
4. Smooth each side separately, keeping the knife angle tight
5. Apply second and third coats, alternating sides each coat

Outside Corners

1. Install corner bead (metal or vinyl) over the corner
2. Secure with screws every 9" on alternating sides
3. Apply compound from the bead nose outward, feathering 8-10"
4. Two coats minimum, sanding between

Types of Corner Bead

Type	Best For	Install Method
Metal (galvanized)	Standard outside corners	Screws or clinch stapler
Vinyl	Moisture-prone areas	Adhesive spray + staples
Paper-faced metal	Best bond, least cracking	Compound + embed
Bullnose	Rounded corner profile	Same as metal

Three-Way Corners

Where two walls meet a ceiling, finish the ceiling joint first, let it dry, then finish the wall corners overlapping the ceiling tape. This creates a clean intersection.

09

JOINT TAPING BASICS

Taping hides the joints between drywall sheets. The goal: make the joint invisible under paint. This takes three coats and patience.

Paper Tape vs Mesh Tape

Feature	Paper Tape	Mesh Tape
Strength	Stronger — better crack resistance	Good for flat joints
Ease of use	Requires bed coat first	Self-adhesive, stick and mud
Inside corners	Pre-creased, ideal	Not suitable
Best with	All-purpose or topping compound	Setting-type compound (hot mud)
Recommendation	Use for all joints	Only flat joints if preferred

First Coat (Tape Coat)

1. Load your 6" knife with compound
2. Apply a thin, even bed coat over the joint — about 1/8" thick, 4" wide
3. Center the tape over the joint, press one end, and unroll
4. Starting from the center, press the tape into the compound with the knife at a 45° angle
5. Squeeze out excess compound on both sides — the tape should be embedded but NOT dry underneath
6. Apply a thin skim coat over the tape immediately
7. Cover all screw heads with a single swipe of compound

PRO TIP

The #1 beginner mistake is too much compound under the tape. You want just enough for adhesion. If you see bubbles, you have too little. If compound squeezes out in ridges, you have too much.

10

APPLYING JOINT COMPOUND

Joint compound (mud) is what makes joints disappear. Understanding the types and proper consistency is critical.

Types of Compound

Type	Drying	Use
All-Purpose (premixed)	Air-dry, 24 hrs	All coats — versatile, easy to sand
Topping (premixed)	Air-dry, 24 hrs	Second and third coats — smoother finish
Setting-type ("hot mud")	Chemical set, 20-90 min	First coat, repairs — fast, hard, crack-resistant
Lightweight	Air-dry, 24 hrs	All coats — easier sanding, less shrinkage

Proper Consistency

Out of the bucket, premixed compound is too thick. Add small amounts of water and mix until it's the consistency of thick mayonnaise for embedding tape, or creamy peanut butter for finish coats. It should hold on an upside-down knife for 2 seconds.

Knife Angles

- **Bed coat:** 45° angle, firm pressure — pushes compound into the joint
- **Skim coat:** 30° angle, light pressure — leaves thin, even layer
- **Feathering:** Nearly flat, very light — blends edge to zero

11

SECOND & THIRD COATS

Each coat widens the joint and smooths imperfections. The goal is a gradual buildup that's invisible to the eye and hand.

Second Coat

- Use a 10" knife
- Widen the compound 2-3" beyond the first coat on each side
- Fill any voids or bubbles from the first coat
- Keep the center thin — build up the edges to create a flat transition
- Re-coat all screw heads
- Let dry 24 hours (or until uniformly white with no dark spots)

Third Coat (Skim Coat)

- Use a 12" knife
- Apply the thinnest possible coat, feathering 2-3" beyond the second coat
- The total width of the finished joint should be 12-14" for tapered joints
- For butt joints: width should be 18-22" to hide the crown
- Skim screw heads one final time

Butt Joint Treatment

Butt joints (where two non-tapered ends meet) are the hardest to hide because they create a crown. The secret: spread the compound VERY wide (18-24") and keep the buildup minimal. A crowned butt joint visible to the eye means your compound isn't wide enough.

PRO TIP

After the second coat dries, run your hand over the joint. If you feel a ridge or bump, knock it down with a knife before applying the third coat. This saves sanding time.

12

FINISHING LEVELS EXPLAINED

The drywall industry defines five finishing levels (0-5), each specifying how much taping and compound is required. Knowing these saves you from over-finishing (wasting time) or under-finishing (callbacks).

Level	Description	Common Use
Level 0	No finishing — bare drywall	Above ceilings, temporary walls
Level 1	Tape embedded in compound (joints only)	Garage interiors, storage, above ceilings in smoke barriers
Level 2	Level 1 + one coat over tape and screws	Behind tile, areas that won't be painted
Level 3	Level 2 + second coat over tape	Areas receiving heavy texture (knockdown, orange peel)
Level 4	Level 3 + third coat, light sanding	Standard painted walls with flat/eggshell paint
Level 5	Level 4 + full skim coat over entire surface	High-sheen paint, critical lighting, smooth walls

NOTE

Most residential work requires Level 4. Charge premium for Level 5 — it takes 40-60% more labor. Specify the level in your proposals to set clear expectations.

13

SANDING TECHNIQUES

Sanding is the bridge between taping and painting. Do it right and joints disappear. Do it wrong and you'll see every imperfection under paint.

Grit Progression

Grit	Purpose	When to Use
120	Rough sanding — knocking down ridges and high spots	After second coat if needed
150	Standard sanding — smoothing compound	After third coat, primary pass
220	Fine sanding — feather edges, final smooth	Final pass before priming

Wet vs Dry Sanding

Dry sanding with a pole sander is faster and more aggressive. It creates significant dust — always use N95 respirator, seal HVAC vents, and plastic off adjacent rooms.

Wet sanding with a damp sponge eliminates dust completely. It's slower and won't remove as much material, but it's ideal for small areas, occupied homes, or final touch-ups.

Technique

1. Use a raking light (work light at a sharp angle to the wall) to reveal imperfections
2. Sand with circular motions, applying even pressure
3. Don't over-sand — exposing the tape or paper face is a common mistake
4. Check your work with the raking light after each pass
5. Vacuum dust before priming

SAFETY

Drywall dust contains silica. Always wear an N95 respirator when dry sanding. Ventilate the area. Consider a dustless sanding system (\$60-\$100) that connects to a shop vac.

14

PRIMING & PAINTING PREP

Priming seals the compound and paper, creating a uniform surface for paint. Skip this step and you'll see "flashing" — joints showing through paint as a different sheen.

Primer Types

Type	Use	Cost
PVA (polyvinyl acetate)	Standard new drywall — seals porous compound and paper equally	\$15-20/gallon
High-build primer	Level 5 finish — fills minor imperfections	\$25-35/gallon
Shellac-based	Stain blocking (water stains, smoke)	\$30-45/gallon

Application

1. Vacuum or wipe all dust from walls
2. Apply primer with roller (3/8" nap for smooth, 1/2" for textured)
3. Cut in corners with a brush
4. Let dry 2-4 hours
5. Inspect with raking light — touch up any imperfections with compound, re-sand, re-prime

Level 5 Skim Coat

For a true Level 5 finish: after priming, apply a thin skim coat of topping compound over the ENTIRE surface using a 14" or 18" knife. Sand smooth with 220-grit. This eliminates any difference between compound and paper texture. Re-prime before paint.

15

DRYWALL TEXTURES

Texture adds visual interest and hides minor imperfections. It's also faster than achieving a perfect Level 4/5 smooth finish.

Common Textures

Texture	Method	Difficulty
Orange Peel	Spray thinned compound with hopper gun, don't flatten	Easy
Knockdown	Spray, wait 10-15 min, flatten with knife	Medium
Skip Trowel	Apply thin compound with curved knife at random angles	Medium-Hard
Popcorn (acoustic)	Spray thick compound mixed with polystyrene	Easy (but dated)
Smooth	Multiple skim coats, sand to perfection	Hard
Slap Brush	Apply compound, slap with brush for pattern	Easy

PRO TIP

Always practice your texture on a scrap piece of drywall before doing the real walls. Texture is hard to undo once applied. Matching existing texture for repairs takes practice — make a test board first.

16

DRYWALL REPAIRS

Knowing how to repair drywall is essential — both for your own installations and as a standalone service that clients need constantly.

Small Holes (up to 4")

1. Clean the edges of the hole
2. Apply self-adhesive mesh patch over the hole
3. Apply 2-3 coats of compound, feathering 6-8" beyond the patch
4. Sand, prime, paint

Medium Holes (4-12") — California Patch

1. Cut a piece of drywall 2" larger than the hole on all sides
2. Score the back, snap off the gypsum, leaving the face paper as a flange
3. Apply compound around the hole
4. Press the patch into the compound — the paper flange adheres to the wall
5. Tape the edges, apply 2-3 coats, sand, prime

Large Holes (12"+) — Cut-and-Patch

1. Square off the hole to the nearest studs on each side
2. Add backing blocks (1×3 or 2×4) behind the opening, screwed to existing drywall
3. Cut new drywall to fit the opening
4. Screw to backing and studs
5. Tape all joints, finish with 3 coats

Water Damage

1. Find and fix the water source FIRST
2. Let the area dry completely (use fans/dehumidifier)
3. Cut out all soft, stained, or moldy drywall — go at least 12" beyond visible damage
4. Inspect framing for mold; treat with borax solution if present
5. Replace with new drywall using the cut-and-patch method

17

MOISTURE & MOLD PREVENTION

Moisture is drywall's worst enemy. Proper material selection and installation techniques prevent costly failures.

Board Selection by Location

Location	Board Type	Notes
Standard rooms	Regular 1/2"	Standard installation
Bathrooms (walls)	Moisture-resistant (green board)	Not behind tub/shower
Behind tub/shower surround	Cement board or?"	Required by code
Kitchen backsplash	Moisture-resistant or cement board	Behind tile
Basement	Mold-resistant (purple board)	Higher humidity environment
Laundry room	Moisture-resistant	Near water sources

Vapor Barriers

In cold climates, install a polyethylene vapor barrier on the warm side of the wall (between insulation and drywall). This prevents warm, moist interior air from condensing inside the wall cavity. In hot-humid climates, the vapor barrier goes on the exterior.

Ventilation

Bathroom fans should be sized at 1 CFM per square foot of floor area (minimum 50 CFM). Run the fan during and 20 minutes after showers. This single step prevents most bathroom mold issues.

18

SOUND & FIRE RATING

Drywall plays a critical role in both fire safety and sound control. Understanding these ratings lets you bid on higher-value projects.

Fire Rating

Assembly	Rating	Construction
Single layer 5/8" Type X	1 hour	Standard garage-to-house wall
Double layer 5/8" Type X	2 hour	Party walls between units
Type C (enhanced)	1-3 hour	Commercial and high-rise applications

Sound Transmission Class (STC)

STC Rating	What You Hear	Example Assembly
33-35	Normal speech heard clearly	Single layer standard drywall
40-45	Loud speech muffled	Insulated wall, single layer each side
50-55	Loud speech barely audible	Double layer, staggered studs, insulation
55+	Most sounds inaudible	Resilient channel, double layer, decoupled

Sound Control Techniques

- **Resilient channel** — Metal channels that decouple drywall from studs, breaking sound transmission
- **Double layer** — Two layers of 5/8" with staggered joints
- **Staggered studs** — Alternate studs between two wall faces so they don't share a stud
- **Sound batts** — Fiberglass or mineral wool insulation in the cavity
- **Acoustic sealant** — Seal all gaps, outlets, and penetrations

19

INSULATION INTEGRATION

As a drywall installer, you'll frequently work alongside or install insulation. Understanding the basics ensures proper installation.

Types of Insulation

Type	R-Value/inch	Best For
Fiberglass batts	R-3.1 to R-3.8	Walls, ceilings, standard cavities
Mineral wool (Rockwool)	R-3.8 to R-4.3	Sound walls, fire-rated assemblies
Blown-in cellulose	R-3.2 to R-3.8	Attics, retrofits (installed before drywall)
Spray foam (closed cell)	R-6 to R-7	Basements, rim joists, air sealing

Key Rules

- Batts should fill the cavity completely — no compression, no gaps
- Cut batts around wires and pipes, don't stuff behind them
- Face the vapor barrier toward the warm side (kraft-faced batts)
- Don't compress insulation with drywall — it reduces R-value
- Seal electrical boxes with foam gaskets to prevent air leaks

20

WORKING EFFICIENTLY

Efficiency is the difference between making \$200/day and \$500/day. These techniques separate professionals from amateurs.

Room Workflow

1. **Prep framing** — Check plumb, add blocking, install nail plates (30 min)
2. **Hang ceiling** — With a lift, one person can do a 12×14 ceiling in 1 hour
3. **Hang walls** — Two people can hang a standard room in 2-3 hours
4. **First coat** — Tape and first mud: 2-3 hours per room, then 24 hr dry
5. **Second coat** — 1-2 hours, then 24 hr dry
6. **Third coat** — 1-2 hours, then 24 hr dry
7. **Sand** — 1-2 hours
8. **Clean and prime** — 1-2 hours

Total for a standard bedroom: ~16-20 hours of labor spread over 4-5 days (drying time).

Time-Saving Tips

- Use setting compound (hot mud) for the first coat — dry in 20-90 min instead of 24 hours
- Pre-fill all screw heads while the first coat of tape dries
- Work multiple rooms: hang Room A, tape Room A, hang Room B, tape Room B — by the time you finish B, A is dry
- Keep your tools clean — dried compound on knives leaves streaks
- Cut all sheets for a wall before hanging any (batch cutting)

PRO TIP

Track your time per room for the first 10 jobs. You'll see clear patterns in what's fast and what's slow. Use this data to quote accurately and identify bottlenecks.

21

QUALITY CHECKLIST

Use this checklist before you call a job complete. Walk the entire space with a raking light (LED work light held at a sharp angle to the wall). Check every item.

Hanging Inspection

- ☐ All screws dimpled (not popped, not too deep)
- ☐ No gaps at joints wider than 1/8"
- ☐ Sheets tight to ceiling
- ☐ 1/4" gap at floor
- ☐ All outlets and switches accessible
- ☐ Corner bead straight and secure

Taping & Finishing Inspection

- ☐ No visible tape edges or bubbles
- ☐ Joints smooth and blended under raking light
- ☐ Butt joints feathered 18"+ wide
- ☐ All screw heads covered (3 coats)
- ☐ Inside corners sharp and clean
- ☐ Outside corners straight (check with 4' level)
- ☐ No sanding scratches visible

Surface Inspection

- ☐ No ridges, craters, or tool marks
- ☐ Paper face not sanded through
- ☐ Surface smooth to the touch (run your hand over it)
- ☐ Raking light reveals no shadows or imperfections
- ☐ Wall is flat — check with 6' straightedge

Final Steps

- ☐ All dust vacuumed or wiped
- ☐ Primer applied evenly to all surfaces
- ☐ Primed surface checked with raking light for touch-ups

- ☐ Cleanup complete — no compound on floors, trim, or fixtures

PRO TIP

Take photos of your finished work before the painter arrives. If issues appear after painting, your photos prove the drywall was perfect at handoff.

NEXT STEP

You now have the complete system to master drywall installation. Here's what to do next:

1

Practice

Start with a small project — a closet, a patch repair, or a single room. Apply what you learned chapter by chapter.

2

Use Your Tools

Open the 200 Blueprints for reference and the Material Calculator for your first quote.

3

Build Your Business

Review the bonus guides — pricing, proposals, business setup — and take your first paid job.